

Neuroscience in India

A leaner, more visual, still exhaustive roadmap for students from many different backgrounds.

This guide is built to answer one practical question: **from your current background, what is the smartest route into neuroscience, cognitive science, computational neuroscience, neuropsychology, or translational brain research in India?**

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IMPORTANT
EXAMS /
GATEWAYS
MAPPED

molecular & cellular

cognitive & behavioural

computational

clinical & translational

UG -> PG -> PhD

Two truths to remember: (1) **India often trains neuroscientists through feeder disciplines** such as biology, psychology, CS, engineering, physics, medicine, and data science. (2) A degree named “neuroscience” is useful, but **not required** to become a neuroscientist.

This is as exhaustive and verified as possible from official programme/admissions pages available at the time of compilation. India does **not** have one single master list of all neuroscience-adjacent programmes, and admission rules can change by cycle. Use this guide to navigate, then confirm the current year's notice on the linked portal.

How to use this PDF

1. Find your track

Molecular, cognitive, computational, or clinical? You do not need to choose forever; you need a strong first direction.

2. Find your stage

Class 11–12, bachelor's, master's, MBBS, BTech, or working professional. Each stage has different gateways.

3. Use the exam map

Most confusion comes from not knowing which exam opens which doors. The exam matrix is built to solve that.

4. Use links at the end

Every major route listed here ends in an official portal link so students can verify live details.

What “best” means here

Not a random ranking. Here, “best” means one or more of these: direct neuroscience / cognitive science identity, strong research ecosystem, strong faculty/lab culture, or a proven feeder route into neuroscience PhDs.

Direct neuroscience / cognitive science identity	82
Research intensity / PhD pipeline value	92
Interdisciplinary flexibility	88
Named clinical / neuropsych utility	67

How the pipeline actually works

In India, neuroscience is usually a **multi-entry pipeline**, not one neat straight line.

Class 11–12

PCM / PCB / any stream

UG feeder degrees

biology • psychology • CS • engineering

PG specialization

MSc / MA / MTech / MS(R)

PhD

research track

Route A

Research-first science
IAT / IISER / IISc style

Route B

Engineering / AI / EE / CS
to computational neuro

Route C

Psychology / cognitive
to cog-neuro / neuropsych

Route D

MBBS / clinical / allied
to translational neuro

What most students get wrong

They search only for degrees named “Neuroscience”.

The stronger strategy is to find the right feeder discipline + the right specialization point.

The best entry point depends on your current background, money, exam appetite, and whether your interest is wet-lab, cogr

Shortcut rule: if you are still in school, optimise for a **high-quality foundational UG**. If you are already in a bachelor's degree, optimise for **methods + internships + the right exam**. If you are already in a master's or MBBS, optimise for **research fit + fellowship route + supervisor fit**.

Clinical warning: “I like the brain” can mean very different careers: neurologist, psychiatrist, clinical psychologist, neuropsychologist, cognitive scientist, wet-lab neuroscientist, or computational neuroscientist. The route changes sharply depending on which of these you mean.

Pick your primary track

You can move between tracks later. But your **first 2–4 years** should be chosen strategically.

Molecular / Cellular

Neurons, synapses, ion channels, disease models, genetics, development, microscopy, animal models, molecular tools.

Cognitive / Behavioural

Attention, memory, decision-making, language, emotion, perception, neuropsychology, behaviour experiments, mind/brain links.

Computational

Neural models, brain-inspired AI, neuroimaging analysis, signal processing, HCI, reinforcement learning, decision science.

Clinical / Translational

Neuro disorders, psychiatry, neurology-linked research, neurophysiology, neuropsych assessment, imaging and intervention.

Best feeder backgrounds

- **Molecular:** BSc/BS life sciences, biotechnology, biochemistry, MBBS, biomedical engineering.
- **Cognitive:** psychology, cognitive science, linguistics, philosophy, BA/BSc with strong methods.
- **Computational:** CS, EE, math, stats, physics, AI/data science, signal processing.
- **Clinical:** MBBS, psychology, allied health, neuroscience technology, neuro-electro physiology.

High-value skills that transfer

- Statistics and experimental design
- Scientific writing and reading
- At least one coding language (Python / R / MATLAB)
- One real project, internship, RAship, or thesis
- Evidence that you can ask and answer a research question

The most useful mindset

Choose the route that gives you the strongest **methods**, not just the fanciest label. A rigorous psychology degree beats a weak “neuroscience” degree; a strong engineering + cognition route beats a random biology degree if your true goal is computational neuroscience.

Fast self-test

1

What excites you most?

Cells & molecules • behaviour & mind • code & models • patients & disorders.

2

What can you realistically study next?

PCM, PCB, psychology, MBBS, BTech, BA/BSc, master's, or working professional.

3

Which exam pain are you willing to take?

JEE / IAT / NEET / JAM / GATE / PGEE / COGJET / JGEEBILS / NET / institute tests.

4

Do you need direct naming?

If yes, target named neuroscience / cognitive science routes. If not, target stronger feeder ecosystems.

Which exam opens which doors?

This is the single most important page for confused applicants.

Exam	Best for	Who should care	Common unlocks	Official link
JEE Main After Class 12	PCM students	Engineering / quantitative UG feeders	NIT/IIT engineering, JEE Advanced eligibility, some university engineering routes	https://jeemain.nta.nic.in/
JEE Advanced After JEE Main	Strong PCM students	Top research UG science / engineering routes	IITs and IISc BS (Research)	https://jeeadv.ac.in/
IAT (IISER Aptitude Test) After Class 12	PCM/PCB students who love science more than professional courses	Research-focused science UG	IISER system and IISc BS (Research)	https://www.iiseradmission.in/
NEET-UG After Class 12	PCB students	Medical route into neuroscience	MBBS/BDS and later clinical neuroscience / neuro research pathways	https://neet.nta.nic.in/
CUET-UG After Class 12	Any stream depending programme	Central-university BA/BSc feeders	Many psychology / life science / interdisciplinary UG routes	https://nta.ac.in/cuetexam
BITSAT After Class 12	PCM students	Private quantitative / science feeder	BITS first-degree programmes	https://admissions.bits-pilani.ac.in/BITSAT_LP/index.html
MET After Class 12 / graduate	Students targeting MAHE	MAHE programmes	MAHE engineering, biotech, allied health and selected PG programmes	https://www.manipal.edu/entrancetest
SRMJEEH / SRM Health-Science route After Class 12 / graduate	Students targeting SRMIST	SRM health / neuroscience technology routes	SRM health-science programmes	https://applications.srmist.edu.in/srmhs
SNUSAT / university route After Class 12	Students targeting SNU	Private feeder ecosystems	Shiv Nadar UG routes	https://ugapplications.snu.edu.in/
Christ ET UG/PG cycle dependent	Students targeting CHRIST	Psychology / neuropsych private routes	Christ psychology and neuropsychology admissions	https://christuniversity.in/uploads/userfiles/file/ADMISSIONS/NEW/BCC/BCC%20PG%20ET%20PROGRAMMES%202026.pdf
Jindal-PMAT After bachelor's	Students targeting JGU	Applied / counselling psychology	JGU psychology master's routes	https://jgu.edu.in/jibs/admissions/mamsc-applied-psychology

Exam map, continued

PG and PhD gateways matter more than students think.

Exam	Best for	Who should care	Common unlocks	Official link
IITGN MSc written test After bachelor's	Any bachelor's background	Cognitive science	IIT Gandhinagar MSc Cognitive Science	https://cogs.iitgn.ac.in/newcogs/cogs-msc/
IIT JAM After bachelor's	BSc / BS / relevant degree students	Science master's	IISc MSc Life Sciences and multiple IIT/IISER PG routes	https://jam2026.iitb.ac.in/
GATE After bachelor's / final year	Engineering / science students	MTech / research / some PhD	IITK Cognitive Systems, research admissions, many engineering and quantitative routes	https://gate2026.iitg.ac.in/
PGEE (IIIT-H) After bachelor's	CS/EE/math/engineering-heavy students	MS/PhD research at IIIT-H	IIIT Hyderabad PG research admissions	https://pgadmissions.iiit.ac.in/pgee/
COGJET After bachelor's	Psychology/science/engineering/management/medical graduates	Cognitive science	CBCS MSc and some PhD routes including IIIT-H-linked cognitive admissions	https://cogjet.in/
JGEEBILS / TIFR GS After bachelor's	Life science / biotech / bioengineering / interdisciplinary students	Life sciences PhD / Int PhD	NCBS / TIFR / partner institutes; some MSc routes like NBRC	https://www.tifr.res.in/academics/jgeebils.php
CSIR-UGC NET / JRF After master's (or as eligible)	Science students, especially life sciences and allied areas	Science PhD funding and eligibility	Many PhD admissions + JRF funding	https://csirnet.nta.nic.in/
UGC-NET / JRF After master's	Psychology, cognitive, social science, humanities streams	Psychology / social-science / cognitive PhD routes	Many PhD admissions and JRF in eligible disciplines	https://ugcnet.nta.nic.in/
DBT-JRF / BET After bachelor's/master's as eligible	Biotech / life-science / molecular candidates	Life-science research funding	Biotech/life-science PhD routes	https://www.ncbs.res.in/academic/admissions-JGEEBILS
ICMR-JRF / INSPIRE / GPAT After bachelor's/master's	Biomedical / pharmacy / life-science students	Biomedical / life-science / pharmacy-linked research	Additional fellowship-based PhD entry routes	https://www.nta.ac.in/

Practical reading of the matrix: **JEE/IAT/NEET** are mostly about school-stage entry. **JAM/GATE/PGEE/COGJET** are specialization levers after UG. **JGEEBILS/TIFR GS/NET/JRF routes** are often the strongest PhD/funding levers.

If you are a PCM student

Best for computational neuroscience, neural engineering, imaging, AI + cognition, and quantitative biology.

Primary route

School focus: PCM + coding + olympiad/problem-solving mindset. Prioritise JEE Main -> JEE Advanced and IAT. If you want engineering-first breadth, use IIT / IIIT / BITS / MAHE engineering feeders. If you want science-first research training, aim for IISc BS (Research) or IISERs.

Good strategy:

Choose the **strongest method-building programme** available to you, then specialize through projects, internships, exams, and a targeted PG/PhD move.

Watch-out:

Do not assume “engineering = not neuroscience”. In India, computational neuroscience is often entered through CS / EE / math first, then specialized at PG/PhD.

1

UG targets

IISc BS (Research) • IISERs • IITs / IIITs / BITS for CS/EE/Math/Physics/Bioengineering • Ashoka/Ahmedabad if you want cognition + liberal arts + data

2

PG targets

IITGN MSc Cognitive Science • IITK MTech / MS Cognitive Science • IIIT-H MS/PhD • UoH CNCS • IISc MSc Life Sciences (if you shift toward bio)

3

PhD targets

NCBS • IISc • JNCASR • IIIT-H • IITK • IITGN • TIFR

4

Build now

Python / MATLAB / data analysis • linear algebra + probability • signals / ML / experimental design • reading papers early

Mini checklist

- Keep transcripts clean.
- Start reading papers early.
- Build one real project.
- Get one strong mentor / referee.
- Learn how admissions in your target track actually work.

If you are a PCB or life-sciences student

Best for molecular, cellular, systems and translational neuroscience.

Primary route

School focus: PCB + statistics + basic coding. Prioritise IAT and NEET depending whether you want research-first or medicine-first training. Also keep strong private options on your list if you want a named neuroscience UG such as SRM or Amrita.

Good strategy:

Choose the **strongest method-building programme** available to you, then specialize through projects, internships, exams, and a targeted PG/PhD move.

Watch-out:

A BSc in plain life sciences is still a valid route. You do not need a degree named "neuroscience" to become a neuroscientist.



UG targets

IISERs • IISc BS
(Research, if eligible profile fits) • MBBS via NEET if clinical neuroscience attracts you • SRM BSc Neuroscience Technology • Amrita BSc Neuro Electro Physiology • MAHE biotech / allied health / psychology feeders



PG targets

NBRC MSc Neuroscience
• Manipal MSc (By Research) Neuroscience
• IITGN MSc Cognitive Science if cognition interests you • UoH CNCS • IISc MSc Life Sciences



PhD targets

NCBS • NBRC • IISc • JNCASR • NIMHANS • TIFR



Build now

Cell bio / genetics / physiology • statistics + research methods • one programming language • lab exposure or internships

Mini checklist

- Keep transcripts clean.
- Start reading papers early.
- Build one real project.
- Get one strong mentor / referee.
- Learn how admissions in your target track actually work.

If you are from psychology / humanities / social sciences

Best for cognitive neuroscience, neuropsychology, behavioural science, language/cognition, and affective science.

Primary route

At UG, prioritise research-method heavy psychology programmes. Add statistics, experimental design, biology-for-behaviour, and some coding. If your programme is qualitative-heavy, compensate with quantitative electives and internships.

Good strategy:

Choose the **strongest method-building programme** available to you, then specialize through projects, internships, exams, and a targeted PG/PhD move.

Watch-out:

In India, cognitive neuroscience often expects more quant skill than a standard BA Psychology gives. Fix this early and you stay competitive.

Mini checklist

- Keep transcripts clean.
- Start reading papers early.
- Build one real project.
- Get one strong mentor / referee.
- Learn how admissions in your target track actually work.

1

UG targets

Ashoka
Psychology & Cognitive Sciences • JGU
Psychology • Ahmedabad University
Psychology • CHRIST
Psychology • strong psychology BA/BSc with methods + stats

2

PG targets

IITGN MSc
Cognitive Science • CBCS
MSc Cognitive Science via COGJET • UoH
CNCS • CHRIST
MSc
Neuropsychology • JGU MSc
Counselling / Applied Psychology

3

PhD targets

Ashoka PhD
Psychology & Cognitive Sciences • IITGN / IITK / IIIT-H (for cognitive research, if you add quant skills) • NCBS / IISc
labs where your background fits the question

4

Build now

statistics + R/Python • experimental methods • cognitive psychology and biological psychology • clear writing sample + research SOP

If you are from CS / AI / data / engineering

Best for computational neuroscience, brain-inspired AI, HCI, neuroimaging analysis, decision science and cognition.

Primary route

Treat neuroscience as an application domain that rewards strong math + coding + modelling + experimentation. Choose projects that touch signals, perception, motor control, imaging, behaviour, or ML for brain/health data.

Good strategy:

Choose the **strongest method-building programme** available to you, then specialize through projects, internships, exams, and a targeted PG/PhD move.

1

UG targets

IIT/IIIT/BITS/MAHE/SNU-style quantitative programmes • add psychology / biology / HCI electives wherever possible

2

PG targets

IIIT-H PGEE routes • IITK Cognitive Science • IITGN Cognitive Science • UoH CNCS • Amrita Computational & Cognitive Neuroscience PhD after suitable prep

3

PhD targets

IIIT-H • IITK • IITGN • NCBS computational labs • JNCASR • IISc quantitative biology / neuro-adjacent groups

4

Build now

probability, linear algebra, optimization • Python / ML / signal processing • experimental design and stats • reading neuroscience papers, not only ML papers

Watch-out:

Pure coding is not enough. Strong candidates can connect models to real behaviour, imaging, neurophysiology, or clinical questions.

Mini checklist

- Keep transcripts clean.
- Start reading papers early.
- Build one real project.
- Get one strong mentor / referee.
- Learn how admissions in your target track actually work.

If you are from MBBS / BDS / allied health / rehab

Best for clinical neuroscience, neuropsychology, cognitive neurology, neurophysiology, psychiatry-linked research and translation.

Primary route

This route is slower but extremely powerful for translational neuroscience. Use clinical exposure as your edge. Add formal research methods, stats, writing, and—if possible—some coding/imaging analysis.

Good strategy:

Choose the **strongest method-building programme** available to you, then specialize through projects, internships, exams, and a targeted PG/PhD move.

Watch-out:

Clinical prestige alone does not substitute for research training. Build a paper trail: projects, posters, audits, case-series, or lab internships.

Mini checklist

- Keep transcripts clean.
- Start reading papers early.
- Build one real project.
- Get one strong mentor / referee.
- Learn how admissions in your target track actually work.



UG targets

MBBS/BDS/ clinical allied programmes via NEET or health-science admissions • Amrita BSc NEP / MAHE allied health can be valid specialised feeders



PG targets

NIMHANS programmes • Christ Neuropsychology • NBRC / Manipal / cognitive science MSc if your background matches and you can demonstrate research interest



PhD targets

NIMHANS • NCBS • NBRC • JNCASR • IISc / TIFR labs tied to disease, imaging, cognition or neurobiology



Build now

biostatistics + epidemiology basics • research ethics and study design • writing + literature review • tool use: imaging / behaviour / data

Flagship public routes

These are the public/government-heavy options most serious neuroscience aspirants should know by name.

Institution	Levels	Track fit	Programmes / identity	Admission route	Official page
IISc Bengaluru Bengaluru · Public	UG / MSc / Research	●●●●● M C Q CI	BS (Research); MSc Life Sciences; Research/PhD ecosystem incl. neuroscience labs	BS (Research): JEE Advanced or IAT (PCM in 10+2). MSc Life Sciences: JAM / GATE + interview. Research programmes: institute portal + programme-specific national test/interview.	https://iisc.ac.in/admissions/
IISER system 7 campuses · Public	UG	●●●●● M C Q CI	5-year BS-MS, 4-year BS, and selected BTech routes (campus-dependent)	IAT through IISER Admissions portal; some programmes/campuses have additional structures but IAT is the key national route.	https://www.iiseradmission.in/
NCBS-TIFR Bengaluru · Public	Integrated PhD / PhD	●●●●● M C Q CI	Integrated PhD and PhD within a top neuroscience & biology research ecosystem	TIFR Graduate Studies / JGEEBILS-style route plus full application and interviews; some cycles also accept high-percentile fellowship routes as specified on NCBS admissions.	https://www.ncbs.res.in/academic/admissions
TIFR DBS / TIFR-H Mumbai / Hyderabad · Public	Integrated PhD / PhD	●●●●● M C Q CI	Biological sciences graduate studies with strong neuroscience-adjacent routes	TIFR GS / JGEEBILS and institution-specific shortlisting + interviews.	https://www.tifr.res.in/academics/gs_advertisement.php
NBRC Manesar / Gurugram · Public	MSc / PhD	●●●●● M C Q CI	MSc in Neuroscience; PhD in Neuroscience	Dedicated NBRC admissions portal/advertisement; PhD admissions also list fellowship/qualifying-exam channels in current notices.	https://www.nbrc.ac.in/
NIMHANS Bengaluru · Public	PG / PhD / clinical training	●●●●● M C Q CI	Broad mental health and neurosciences portfolio across clinical, translational and research tracks	Year-specific PG / PhD prospectus, entrance exam calendar and interviews on NIMHANS admissions pages.	https://www.nimhans.ac.in/academics/admissions

● strong fit ● moderate fit ● adjacent / feeder fit

Public routes, continued

The “named” degree matters less than the lab ecology and the admission route you can realistically unlock.

Institution	Levels	Track fit	Programmes / identity	Admission route	Official page
IIT Gandhinagar (Cognitive & Brain Sciences) Gandhinagar · Public	MSc / PhD	 M C Q CI	MSc Cognitive Science; PhD in Cognitive & Brain Sciences	MSc uses IITGN's own written test + interview and is open to any bachelor's degree; PhD through IITGN research admissions.	https://cogs.iitgn.ac.in/newcogs/cogs-msc/
IIT Kanpur (Cognitive Science) Kanpur · Public	MTech / MS(R) / PhD	 M C Q CI	MTech Cognitive Systems; MS by Research; PhD; internal minor/dual-degree ecosystem	Recent official routes use GATE / CSIR-JRF / NET / equivalent for MS/PhD and GATE for MTech (with institute-specific exemptions where applicable).	https://www.cgs.iitk.ac.in/
IIIT Hyderabad Hyderabad · Public-private deemed	MS by Research / PhD	 M C Q CI	Research-intensive MS/PhD ecosystem; important for computational neuroscience, AI, HCI and cognition-adjacent labs	PGEE and research-admissions portals; some cognitive routes also intersect with COGJET-linked pipelines.	https://pgadmissions.iiit.ac.in/
University of Hyderabad (CNCS) Hyderabad · Public	MSc / PhD	 M C Q CI	MSc and PhD via Centre for Neural and Cognitive Sciences	University route / national-test-linked route depending the cycle; CNCS page explicitly lists neuroscience and cognitive science streams.	https://centres.uohyd.ac.in/cncls/
JNCASR (Neuroscience Unit) Bengaluru · Public	Integrated BS(Research) / PhD / Int PhD / MS(R) / PhD / MSc Interdisciplinary Biosciences	 M C Q CI	Multiple entry points into neuroscience through a research-centre model	JNCASR annual admissions; neuroscience unit accepts relevant science/engineering/MBBS backgrounds and national exams as specified for each programme.	https://www.jncasr.ac.in/admission/admissions
CBCS, University of Allahabad Prayagraj · Public	MSc	 M C Q CI	MSc Cognitive Science	COGJET joint entrance route (current portal states CBCS MSc uses COGJET).	https://cogjet.in/

Private & specialised routes

Especially useful when you want a named programme, a private ecosystem, or a stronger psychology/clinical/cognitive launchpad.

Institution	Levels	Track fit	Programmes / identity	Admission route	Official page
Manipal (KMC/ MAHE) Manipal · Private	UG / MSc / PhD-adjacent feeder	●●●● M C Q CI	MSc (By Research) in Neuroscience; strong allied-health / biotech / psychology feeders	Course-specific MAHE portal; some programmes use MET, others department tests or national exams.	https://www.manipal.edu/kmc-manipal/program-list/msc-research-neuroscience.html
SRMIST Chennai and other campuses · Private	UG / PG	○●○○● M C Q CI	BSc Neuroscience Technology and related health-science/ biotech options	Health-science admissions through SRM's own entrance processes (e.g. SRMJEEH) and programme-specific criteria.	https://www.srmist.edu.in/program/b-sc-neurosciences-technology/
Amrita Vishwa Vidyapeetham Multiple campuses · Private	UG / PhD	○●●●● M C Q CI	BSc Neuro Electro Physiology; PhD in Computational and Cognitive Neuroscience; broader sciences PhD options incl. computational neuroscience	UG via AEEL/health-science route as specified; PhD via Amrita entrance + interview.	https://www.amrita.edu/program/ph-d-in-computational-and-cognitive-neuroscience/
CHRIST (Deemed to be University) Bengaluru and other campuses · Private	UG / PG / PhD	○●○○○ M C Q CI	MSc Neuropsychology plus multiple psychology degrees; social neuroscience faculty presence	Christ selection process uses entrance test / skill assessment / micro-presentation / personal interview for relevant PG cycles.	https://christuniversity.in/courses/NTAz
Ashoka University Sonipat · Private	UG / PG Diploma / PhD	○●○○○ M C Q CI	UG in Psychology & Cognitive Sciences; Ashoka Scholars Programme; PhD in Psychology & Cognitive Sciences	Holistic UG admissions; department-specific PhD recruitment and screening.	https://www.ashoka.edu.in/department/department-of-psychology/
O.P. Jindal Global University Sonipat · Private	UG / PG	○●○○○ M C Q CI	BA/BSc Psychology; MSc Counselling Psychology; MA/MSc Applied Psychology	UG uses university admissions; multiple PG psychology programmes explicitly use Jindal-PMAT + personal interaction (or accepted alternatives in some cases).	https://jgu.edu.in/jspc/
Ahmedabad University Ahmedabad · Private	UG / PhD	○●○○○ M C Q CI	BA (Hons) Psychology and doctoral options in School of Arts and Sciences	Holistic university admissions with personal interaction; doctoral admissions use graduate portal + interview + national tests where specified.	https://ahduni.edu.in/majors/psychology/
	UG / PG / PhD	○●●○○ M C Q CI	UG psychology and science/engineering	UG via SNUSAT/APT, SAT/ ACT or JEE Main routes as	

Institution	Levels	Track fit	Programmes / identity	Admission route	Official page
Shiv Nadar University, Delhi-NCR Greater Noida · Private			feeders; graduate and doctoral ecosystem in a research-intensive multidisciplinary university	specified by SNU; master's and PhD via university graduate admissions portal and school/departmental criteria.	https://snu.edu.in/admissions/
BITS Pilani Pilani / Goa / Hyderabad · Private	UG / PhD	 M C Q CI	No dedicated neuroscience UG, but strong physics / biology / CS / math feeder routes plus doctoral admissions	BITSAT for first-degree UG routes; doctoral admissions through BITS PhD portal.	https://www.bits-pilani.ac.in/admissions/

Private-university caution: do not choose on branding alone. Compare curriculum depth, research culture, affordability, labs, faculty fit, and where alumni go for PG/PhD.

How PhD entry really works

Most Indian neuroscience PhD applicants enter through one of four architectures.

Route 1

4-year BS/BTech/BS-MS -> direct PhD c

JNCASR / NCBS / IISc / IITGN*

(*programme-specific rules apply)

Route 2

3-year BA/BSc -> MSc/MA/MTech/MS(F

Most common path

especially for psychology / life sciences

Route 3

Master's / MBBS + fellowship score ->

CSIR / UGC / DBT / ICMR / GATE

very important for funded research entry

Route 4

Institute written test + interviews

IITGN / Christ / JGU / some centre-specific routes

especially private or department-run admissions

Your PhD package should include:

- one clear research direction
- a supervisor/lab fit, not just institute prestige
- exam / fellowship route or institute-specific eligibility
- SOP / statement of purpose matched to faculty
- evidence: project / thesis / internship / publications
- references that can actually comment on your research
- methods fit: stats / coding / wet lab / imaging / clinical

The PhD is about question-methods-mentor fit

The institute name matters, but it is not the v

What to build before applying

- research CV
- targeted SOP for each lab
- transcript + scorecard + proof of fellowship
- methods readiness
- 2-3 faculty whose work you can explain

What selection committees usually watch for

- clarity of motivation
- fit with programme and faculty
- evidence you can survive research
- trainability
- thinking depth more than polished jargon

Where the strongest routes cluster

A deliberately simplified picture: it shows the relative concentration of options, not a formal ranking.

Public / govt routes by character

Direct neuroscience centres	7
Cognitive science specialists	5
Research-first UG feeders	8
Clinical / translational anchors	4

Private routes by character

Named neuroscience / neuro-tech UG	3
Strong psychology / cognition launchpads	6
Private research-university feeders	5
Clinical / neuropsych specialisation	3

Bottom line

For **basic neuroscience research**, public institutes still dominate. For **cognitive / psychology / neuropsych preparation**, a number of private universities are now serious players. For **computational neuroscience**, the strongest Indian routes often begin in engineering, CS, math, or cognitive science rather than in a degree named neuroscience.

Fast decision table

I want hard-core lab neuroscience.

Prioritise: IISER / IISc / NBRC / NCBS / JNCASR / TIFR / UoH. Private add-ons: Manipal, Amrita.

I want cognition, behaviour, mind, perception.

Prioritise: IITGN / IITK / UoH CNCS / CBCS / Ashoka / JGU / CHRIST / Ahmedabad.

I want code + brain + AI.

Prioritise: IITK / IIIT-H / IITGN / IISc / BITS / strong CS/ EE feeders + cognitive science overlap.

I want clinic-facing neuroscience.

Prioritise: NIMHANS / MBBS route / neurophysiology / neuropsychology / translational labs.

What strong applicants usually have

Students often over-focus on exam scores and under-focus on the actual application package.

UG application packet

- Class 10 and 12 marksheets / predicted scores
- Exam scorecards where applicable (JEE / IAT / NEET / BITSAT / university tests)
- Personal statement or essays for holistic universities
- Activity portfolio only if it genuinely shows curiosity / rigor
- Financial aid documents where needed

PG / PhD application packet

- research CV (not a job resume)
- statement of purpose tailored to programme + faculty
- transcript and degree proof
- exam/fellowship scorecards (JAM, GATE, NET, JGEEBILS, PGEE, etc.)
- writing sample / project report / thesis abstract if asked
- 2–3 letters of recommendation

What a smart SOP usually does

- states your question-space clearly
- shows why this programme and these faculty matter
- connects your background to the target track
- demonstrates methods readiness honestly
- sounds like a future researcher, not like a brochure

Funding & fellowship reality

- Science-track PhDs often hinge on JRF / fellowship routes
- Psychology / cognitive routes may use UGC-NET, institute fellowship, or self/other funding depending programme
- Some elite institutes run their own funded research admissions
- Always read the current notice carefully: fellowship rules, stipends, and eligibility can shift by cycle

A “beautiful” CV without evidence is weak. One real project, one good referee, and one honest methods story usually matter more than a pile of generic certificates.

Official links to check next

Use these to verify current-year notices, forms, syllabi, and deadlines.

National exams & admissions portals

JEE Main	https://jeemain.nta.nic.in/
JEE Advanced	https://jeeadv.ac.in/
IISER Admissions / IAT	https://www.iiseradmission.in/
NEET UG	https://neet.nta.nic.in/
CUET UG	https://nta.ac.in/cuetexam
CUET PG	https://exams.nta.nic.in/cuet-pg/
IIT JAM	https://jam2026.iitb.ac.in/
GATE	https://gate2026.iitg.ac.in/
CSIR-UGC NET	https://csirnet.nta.nic.in/
UGC-NET	https://ugcnet.nta.nic.in/
IIIT-H PGEE	https://pgadmissions.iiit.ac.in/pgee/
COGJET	https://cogjet.in/
TIFR / JGEEBILS	https://www.tifr.res.in/academics/jgeebils.php
JoSAA	https://josaa.nic.in/
NTA main portal	https://www.nta.ac.in/

Flagship public routes

IISc Admissions	https://iisc.ac.in/admissions/
NCBS Admissions	https://www.ncbs.res.in/academic/admissions
NCBS Integrated PhD	https://www.ncbs.res.in/academic/int-phd
NCBS PhD	https://www.ncbs.res.in/academic/phd
NBRC	https://www.nbrc.ac.in/
NIMHANS Admissions	https://www.nimhans.ac.in/academics/admissions
IITGN Cognitive Science	https://cogs.iitgn.ac.in/newcogs/cogs-msc/
IITK Cognitive Science	https://www.cgs.iitk.ac.in/
UoH CNCS	https://centres.uohyd.ac.in/cncs/
JNCASR Admissions	https://www.jncasr.ac.in/admission/admissions
CBCS / COGJET note	https://cbcs.ac.in/cogjet-2026-cognitive-science-joint-entrance-test-for-masters-and-phd-program/

Official links, continued

Especially useful for private / specialised routes and university-specific processes.

Private / specialised routes

Manipal MSc Neuroscience	https://www.manipal.edu/kmc-manipal/program-list/msc-research-neuroscience.html
MAHE entrance test	https://www.manipal.edu/entrancetest
SRMIST BSc Neuroscience Technology	https://www.srmist.edu.in/program/b-sc-neurosciences-technology/
SRM health-science admissions	https://applications.srmist.edu.in/srmhs
Amrita PhD Computational and Cognitive Neuroscience	https://www.amrita.edu/program/ph-d-in-computational-and-cognitive-neuroscience/
Amrita BSc Neuro Electro Physiology	https://www.amrita.edu/program/bsc-neuro-electro-physiology/
CHRIST MSc Neuropsychology	https://christuniversity.in/courses/NTAZ
CHRIST PG selection process PDF	https://christuniversity.in/uploads/userfiles/file/ADMISSIONS/NEW/BCC/BCC%20PG%20ET%20PROGRAMME%202026.pdf
Ashoka Psychology & Cognitive Sciences	https://www.ashoka.edu.in/department/department-of-psychology/
Ashoka PhD (Psychology & Cognitive Sciences)	https://www.ashoka.edu.in/programme/phd-programme-in-psychology/
JGU Psychology	https://jgu.edu.in/jspc/
JGU MA/MSc Applied Psychology	https://jgu.edu.in/jibs/admissions/mamsc-applied-psychology
Ahmedabad University UG admissions	https://ahduni.edu.in/admission/undergraduate-admission/

Final reminders

1. Check the current cycle	The same programme can change its exam route, eligibility phrasing, deadline, or interview process from one year to the next.
2. Read both the department and central admissions page	Department pages explain research identity; central portals explain forms, fees, and deadlines.
3. Track “named” and “feeder” options together	Many of the strongest neuroscientists in India did not start in a degree named neuroscience.
4. Build methods early	Stats, coding, experimental design, writing, and one serious project will keep opening doors.
5. Use this guide like a map, not a verdict	Your best route depends on fit, not just prestige.

Suggested next step for a student: make your own shortlist of 8–12 programmes across one “dream” band, one “fit” band, and one “safe” band; then map each to exact exam + timeline + documents.

Ahmedabad University Psychology
major

[https://
ahduni.edu.in/
majors/psychology/](https://ahduni.edu.in/majors/psychology/)

BITS Pilani admissions

[https://www.bits-
pilani.ac.in/
admissions/](https://www.bits-pilani.ac.in/admissions/)